

A PRACTICAL PLAYBOOK

From Product Images to a Ready-to-Share Catalogue

A repeatable workflow for turning clean product assets, lifestyle visuals and a product master into a polished catalogue with AI.

IMAGE ASSETS

Make every product easy to recognize.

PRODUCT MASTER

Make every detail easy to trust.

AI ASSEMBLY

Make the final document easy to use.

Designed as a viewer guide - adapt the placeholders to your products, channel and brand.



IMAGE + DATA + SYSTEM

A catalogue is a system, not a pile of photos

The best result comes from separating three jobs: make the product visually reliable, make the information structurally reliable, then let AI handle the assembly work.



WHY THIS ORDER WORKS

Each stage fixes a different kind of catalogue problem.

01 Clean base assets

White background images create a dependable reference for product identity, proportions and finish.

02 Add context

Lifestyle shots show scale, mood and use without replacing the product reference image.

03 Structure data

A product master turns scattered pricing, SKUs and descriptions into a source of truth.

04 Assemble once

Claude or Codex can now map files to rows and build consistent catalogue pages.

THE PRINCIPLE

AI should decide layout and polish; it should not guess your product identity, price or SKU.

Start with a clean folder and a clear data contract

A good catalogue brief is boring in the best way: every product has a stable name, a stable SKU, and a predictable place for its images and details.

RECOMMENDED PROJECT FOLDER

```
catalogue-project/
  product-master.xlsx
  brand-notes.txt
  images/
    SKU-001_white.jpg
    SKU-001_lifestyle.jpg
    SKU-002_white.jpg
  output/
```

A predictable naming pattern makes image-to-row matching much safer.

THE PRODUCT MASTER: CORE COLUMNS

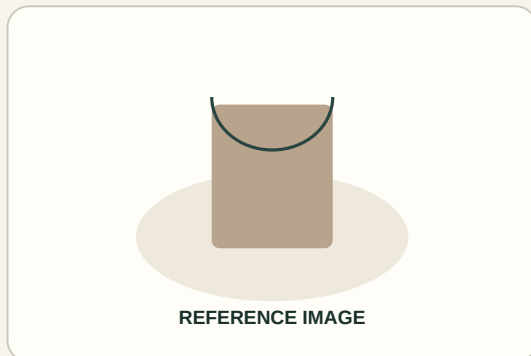
FIELD	WHAT IT CONTROLS	EXAMPLE
SKU	Unique match key	SKU-001
Product name	Page title	Everyday Tote
Category	Grouping / filters	Bags
Selling price	Visible price	Rs. 1,499
Short description	Product copy	Structured cotton tote...
Key features	Bullets / highlights	Zip closure; inner pocket
White image	Reference asset	SKU-001_white.jpg
Lifestyle image	Context asset	SKU-001_lifestyle.jpg

THE DATA CONTRACT

One row = one sellable product or variant. One SKU = one stable identifier. One image filename = one exact file. If a value is unknown, leave it blank or label it as TBD - never silently invent it.

Create white background images first

These are your product truth images. They are useful for catalogue grids, marketplace listings, product pages and as reference inputs for every later visual.



What to protect

- Exact product shape, proportions and construction
- True color and finish under neutral lighting
- Entire product visible with enough breathing room
- No props, text, logos or decorative background
- A small, natural grounding shadow is acceptable

COPY-READY PROMPT - WHITE BACKGROUND

Create a clean e-commerce product image of [PRODUCT NAME]. Use [REFERENCE IMAGE / UPLOAD] as the exact identity reference. Show the complete product, centered and fully visible, in a [FRONT / 3-QUARTER / TOP] view. Preserve the real shape, proportions, seams, hardware, texture, color and finish. Place it on a pure white #FFFFFF background with soft, neutral studio lighting and a subtle grounded shadow. No props, hands, people, extra objects, text, watermark, packaging changes or invented details. Make the product look like a premium catalogue asset, sharp enough for a product page.

IMAGE PROMPT

CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

Compare the generated image to the original product. If the product has changed, regenerate with a stronger reference instruction - do not use the image just because the background looks clean.

Use lifestyle shots to show the product in a believable world

Lifestyle images answer a different question: What does this product feel like in use? They should add scale and emotion while staying faithful to the reference asset.

THE SCENE SETUP FORMULA

PRODUCT

[exact product]

SETTING

[place + time]

PROPS

[2-4 supporting props]

MOOD

[light + feeling]

COPY-READY PROMPT - LIFESTYLE SHOT

Create a premium lifestyle product image using [WHITE BACKGROUND PRODUCT IMAGE / UPLOAD] as the exact product reference. Place [PRODUCT NAME] in [SETTING: e.g. a sunlit studio desk / boutique shelf / outdoor cafe / bathroom vanity]. Include [SCENE PROPS: list 2-4 props] that support the story but do not compete with the product. The product should be [PLACEMENT: hero object / worn by a person / held in hand / used in context] and remain clearly visible. Use [LIGHTING: soft morning light / warm evening light / diffused daylight] and create a [MOOD: calm / premium / energetic / earthy] feeling. Keep the product's shape, color, materials, branding and proportions unchanged. Realistic commercial photography, natural composition, controlled depth of field, no text, no watermark, no invented product features.

IMAGE PROMPT

KEEP IT BELIEVABLE

Give the scene a job: show scale, use, texture, gifting, styling or atmosphere. A random pretty background is not a lifestyle image.

ONE PRODUCT, ONE STORY

Reuse the same product reference across angles so the catalogue feels consistent and trustworthy.

Make the spreadsheet your source of truth

The product master is what keeps the final catalogue useful. It is also the part that should be easiest to update when prices, inventory or descriptions change.

A PRACTICAL COLUMN SET

GROUP	RECOMMENDED FIELDS	WHY IT MATTERS
Identity	SKU, product name, variant	Maps every asset to the right item
Merchandising	Category, subcategory, tags	Creates sections and filters
Commercial	Selling price, compare-at price, tax	Keeps visible pricing accurate
Description	Short copy, key features, care	Feeds the page without retyping
Operations	Stock status, lead time, MOQ	Sets buyer expectations
Assets	White image, lifestyle image	Links rows to the right files
Brand	Collection, season, badge	Adds context when needed

QUALITY RULES FOR THE MASTER

- Keep currency, date and price format consistent.
- Keep every SKU unique.
- Write descriptions for customers, not your database.
- Match exact filenames and extensions.
- Use a Notes column for exceptions.

THE SIMPLE TEST

Can a new person open the sheet and identify what to sell, how much it costs and which images belong to it without asking you a question? If not, clean the master before sending it to AI.

Give Claude or Codex a complete, inspectable brief

AI works best when the request includes the files, the output format, the page rules and the rules for uncertainty. Tell it what it may decide - and what it must never guess.

BEFORE YOU UPLOAD

- Excel file opens and has one header row
- All images use stable filenames
- Every SKU has the right asset pair
- Brand colours and logo are available
- Page size and audience are decided
- Missing values are marked clearly

A SIMPLE BRIEF

Audience	Who will read this?
Use case	WhatsApp, sales team, print, website
Format	A4 PDF, mobile PDF, or both
Grouping	By category, collection or use
Tone	Minimal, premium, playful, technical
CTA	Order, enquire, visit, scan, call

WHY THE BRIEF MATTERS

Without a brief, AI will often produce a visually neat document that is wrong for the moment of use: too dense for WhatsApp, too sparse for print, too promotional for a buyer, or too generic for your brand.

Master prompt for Claude or Codex

Paste this after attaching the product master, image folder and any brand references.
Replace the bracketed values before you run it.

COPY / PASTE

MASTER PROMPT - PART 1 OF 2

You are a catalogue production assistant. Build a complete, polished product catalogue from the attached files.

PROJECT CONTEXT

- Brand: [BRAND NAME]
- Business / category: [BUSINESS TYPE]
- Audience: [TARGET BUYER]
- Main use: [WHATSAPP / SALES TEAM / WEBSITE / PRINT / OTHER]
- Output: [A4 PDF / MOBILE PDF / BOTH]
- Catalogue title: [TITLE]
- Call to action: [ORDER / ENQUIRE / VISIT / SCAN / CALL]

FILES TO INSPECT

1. [PRODUCT MASTER FILE NAME] - the source of truth for all product data.
2. [IMAGES FOLDER NAME] - white background and lifestyle assets.
3. [BRAND REFERENCES] - logo, colours, fonts, contact details and any existing brand rules.

FIRST, AUDIT THE INPUTS

- Read the spreadsheet structure and identify the header row.
- List every sheet, column and row count before designing.
- List every image filename and infer its SKU only from the filename or an exact match in the spreadsheet.
- Build a match report: matched products, missing images, duplicate SKUs, orphan images and missing commercial fields.
- Stop and ask for clarification only where a mismatch can change product identity, price or availability. For lower-risk gaps, label the value as [TBD] in the draft and flag it in the QA report.

UPLOAD TIP

Attach the spreadsheet and the complete images folder together. If the tool cannot inspect folders, compress the folder without changing filenames.

Tell the AI how to design, validate and deliver

The second half turns a file-reading task into a production brief. It protects product truth while giving the model enough room to make the catalogue feel designed.

COPY / PASTE

MASTER PROMPT - PART 2 OF 2

NOW BUILD THE CATALOGUE

- Use SKU as the primary join key. Never join products by approximate name if a SKU exists.
- Keep all prices, product names, categories, specifications and availability exactly as provided in the master.
- Use the white background image as the primary product image. Use the lifestyle image as a secondary visual or section opener where it improves the story.
- Do not stretch, crop out key product details, recolour, redesign, merge or invent products.
- Create a clear cover, a short contents / category overview if useful, category dividers where needed, consistent product pages or cards, and a final contact / CTA page.
- Each product entry should show: product name, SKU, price, short description, key features and the relevant image(s). Only show fields that contain reliable data.
- Use [BRAND COLOURS], [TYPE STYLE] and [VISUAL MOOD] consistently. Prioritise legibility at [VIEWING SIZE].
- Keep page rhythm varied but repeatable: hero image, product information, price and CTA should be easy to scan.

OUTPUTS

1. Final catalogue PDF named [FINAL FILE NAME].
2. A preview / contact sheet of every page.
3. A QA report with: products included, products excluded, unresolved mismatches, missing fields, image swaps, invented content (must be zero), and final page count.
4. If you create HTML or source files, keep them editable and make the PDF export reproducible.

FINAL QA BEFORE DELIVERY

- Check every SKU appears once unless the brief explicitly requests variants.
- Check every visible price against the spreadsheet.
- Check image-to-product mapping on every page.
- Check no text, image or CTA is clipped at the final page size.
- Check fonts, contrast, whitespace and page breaks.
- Check the PDF opens correctly and the page count matches the QA report.

Do not claim the catalogue is complete until this QA pass is done. Report any remaining uncertainty clearly at the end.

THE NON-NEGOTIABLE LINE

Do not invent product facts, prices, SKUs, dimensions, materials, stock status or claims. If the source does not contain it, leave it out or mark it as TBD.

The catalogue is ready when the file is trustworthy

AI can make a document look finished before it is actually safe to share. Run a fast human review across four layers before sending it to buyers or customers.

DATA QA

Do prices, SKUs, names and categories match the master?

- Spot-check first, middle and last product in each section
- Confirm price formatting did not change the value
- Check CTA and contact details

IMAGE QA

Does every image show the right product?

- Compare lifestyle shots to the white reference
- Check crops, sharpness and colour consistency
- Look for AI artefacts or missing parts

LAYOUT QA

Can someone scan it quickly at the real viewing size?

- Check mobile or print view at 100%
- Look for clipping, awkward breaks or crowding
- Keep product name, price and CTA obvious

BUSINESS QA

Does the document help someone take the next step?

- Show ordering / enquiry instructions clearly
- Add delivery, MOQ or lead-time notes when relevant
- Remove placeholder text before sharing

EXPORT STANDARD

Export at the final page size, embed fonts where possible, inspect a rendered page preview, and keep the editable source next to the PDF so updates do not require rebuilding from zero.

Make the next catalogue faster

Once the first catalogue is clean, the real payoff is repeatability. Keep the file structure, prompts and QA report as a small production system you can reuse for every new collection.

THE REPEATABLE LOOP

01

Add products

Create the white background reference and lifestyle image for each new SKU.

02

Update master

Add the new row, price, category, descriptions and exact filenames.

03

Run the audit

Let AI find mismatches before it touches the catalogue layout.

04

Re-export

Regenerate the catalogue and review only the changed pages plus the final QA.

KEEP THESE THREE FILES

1. Product master | 2. Prompt pack | 3. QA report

The catalogue workflow in one page

- 1 Create clean white background images**

Use the real product as reference. Preserve identity above all.
- 2 Create lifestyle images**

Choose a setting, props, lighting and mood that show how the product fits into life.
- 3 Build the product master**

Keep one row per product or variant. Use SKU and exact filenames.
- 4 Upload the full handoff**

Give Claude or Codex the spreadsheet, images, brand notes and output brief.
- 5 Run the master prompt**

Let AI map, design and assemble. Tell it what it must never invent.
- 6 Review the final PDF**

Check data, images, layout and business details before sharing.

THE END RESULT

One folder. One source of truth. One repeatable prompt. One catalogue your customers can actually use.

Want help applying this to your business?

Choose the next step based on where you are right now.

BOOK A CONSULTATION

Talk through your catalogue, workflow or AI idea with me.

shashwatagarwal.com/call

START A PROJECT

If you are ready to build, send the details of your project.

shashwatagarwal.com/work-with-us

EMAIL

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